5

THE DIVIDE

"America is something that can be easily moved."

Benjamin Netanyahu

In the basement of Jerusalem's posh Inbal Hotel, hundreds of American rabbis were gathered. They had flown in for the annual gathering of the Central Conference of American Rabbis (CCAR), the umbrella organization for Reform Jewry in the United States and Canada, the largest community in North America, with some 1.5 million members. Its rabbis hold their conference in Jerusalem once every seven years.

Their 2016 visit, in many ways, had a celebratory feel. Three weeks earlier, the Israeli cabinet had decided to create an egalitarian prayer space at the Western Wall, the holiest site where Jews are allowed to worship. It was seen as a hard-fought victory for activists who had worked for decades to challenge the gender segregation enforced by the ultra-Orthodox rabbinate. They had been further heartened by a 11 February High Court decision that required public *mikvot*, or ritual baths, to open their doors for non-Orthodox converts. "It's an incredibly significant moment for our community," said Steven Fox, a Los Angeles native who serves as CCAR's chief executive.

But it wasn't all a victory lap. Midway through the first day of the conference, a staff member took to the podium with the warning that the rabbis should prepare themselves for some heckling in the Knesset later in the week. They were due to address a session of the parliament's immigration committee, which also handles relations with the Jewish diaspora. A few days earlier, however, a *haredi* lawmaker had described the Reform community as "mentally ill". David Yosef, a member of the ultra-Orthodox Shas party's Council of Sages, called them "literally idolators".